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LANGUAGE EDUCATION: VARIOUS POLICIES AND MULTILINGUALISM

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1.1 INTRODUCTION

Being a country of various ethnicities, traditions, and religions, Bharat is home to over a billion people who communicate in innumerable dialects and official languages. The country is a linguistic marvel where in every few hundred kilometers, the language changes. Each language is unique with its own syntax and grammar, and switching between languages is an effortless process. Thus, multilingualism forms the warp and weft of the rich tapestry of communication and is an essential component of the country's identity, serving as a symbol of unity and diversity. The Indian Constitution recognises 22 languages under the Eighth Schedule, while countless others thrive within regional and tribal communities, contributing to the font of ' vibrant linguistic landscape. So, in a country as diverse as ours, multilingualism is not just a choice but a way of life.

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**Fig. 1.1: Languages Spoken by the People of Indian States
(Maps of India, 2025)**

Language stands at the core of all communication and forms the foundation of all learning. It is the vehicle for the expression of our innermost feelings and emotions. Language, in turn, also shapes and moulds the way in which children think, express, and connect with the world around them. India is a land of multiple languages set across its vast landscape. The variety and richness that our languages offer make us stand unique among the countries of the world. It is a well-known fact that young growing children acquire different languages at home, at school, and in their communities. It may depend upon the exposure of the child that s/he may acquire only one language spoken at home or two or more languages as spoken around them.

In this varied tapestry, language education in schools becomes an interesting aspect. It is to be noted that language learning in schools is not just about learning one language, but it is about building on the previous knowledge of the child and letting them learn and acquire new languages in a joyful and stress-free environment. This may appear to be lopsided and bring in both challenges as well as opportunities for teachers to explore and look for solutions wherein every child feels confident, included, and supported, no matter which language they speak.

The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, along with the National Curriculum Framework for the Foundational Stage (NCF-FS 2022) and the National

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Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCF-SE 2023), provide guidance in this matter, thereby highlighting the importance of the home language of children, particularly during early education. The policy and other documents highly recommend that the transition from home to school should be made easy for children, and the home language can act as a bridge between the two. The policy emphasises that children should begin their education in the language that they are most comfortable with and understand best, which is usually the home language or the mother tongue. If teachers practice this approach, classroom transactions would become more natural, meaningful, and joyful.

This chapter will discuss the key provisions related to Language Education as recommended in NEP 2020 and NCFs regarding teaching and learning processes to be used in a language classroom at the primary stage. It will better equip teachers with the strategies and techniques to make language acquisition a more relevant and respectful task, which is rooted in the lived experiences of the children they teach.



1.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After the completion of the chapter, the learner:

- Appreciates the fundamental features of Language Education in NEP 2020 and NCFs regarding language education at the primary stage;
- Explains the concept of bi/multilingualism and how it supports learning and thinking;
- Recognises bi/multilingualism as a resource in the classroom;
- Identifies challenges in implementing bi/multilingualism in the class and suggests practical solutions;
- Designs simple classroom activities that promote bi/multilingualism.

1.3 LANGUAGE EDUCATION POLICIES IN INDIA

All of us will agree that Bharat is the most linguistically diverse country in the world. Children in our classrooms come with rich experiences and varied language backgrounds. The earlier policies and commissions have emphatically championed the cause of this linguistic diversity and the respect that should be given to the varied experiences of the students.

Over time, several national commissions such as the Kothari Commission

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(1964–66), the National Policy on Education (1986, updated in 1992), and most recently, the NEP 2020, have laid down recommendations on language use in schools. All the earlier documents emphasise the idea that children learn best when they are taught in the language that they can emotionally connect with, i.e., the language they speak at home.

The NEP 2020, NCF-FS 2022, and NCF-SE 2023, move a step ahead and have recommended concrete ways to integrate the home languages of children in the process of teaching and learning, especially in the Foundational and Preparatory stages. Let us look at the key recommendations from NEP 2020.

1.3.1 Key Recommendations from NEP 2020

Home Language/Mother Tongue as Medium of Instruction: The policy clearly states that children should be taught as far as possible, at least until grade 5 and preferably up to grade 8 and beyond in their home language. It has been proven by research that children learn better and build stronger relationships when they are taught in their home language.

Flexible Three-Language Formula: The policy reiterates and emphasise the three-language formula as opined in the earlier policies and documents. It suggests that children should learn three languages in school, but gives flexibility to the State in the choice of the language based on regional and cultural needs. The following pattern is suggested:

- (i) Mother Tongue/Regional Language – Ensures cultural grounding and local relevance.
- (ii) Hindi (or any other modern Indian language) – Encourages national integration.
- (iii) English/Other Foreign Language – Prepares students for global opportunities.

This formula not only provides an atmosphere of inclusion but also helps in promoting national unity and mutual respect for linguistic diversity. It also helps in bridging national and global opportunities, as students gain proficiency in regional, national, and international languages, ensuring they are well-equipped for diverse prospects.

Early Exposure to Multiple Languages: The policy recommends early exposure to multiple languages, thereby promoting multilingualism. The acquisition of multiple languages will not be restricted merely for the purpose of

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communication but would also aid cognitive development, as it is an established fact that multilingualism enhances brain function and develops higher-order thinking skills.

English as a Subject: NEP 2020 propagates the idea of teaching English as a subject within a multilingual framework, especially at the primary level, allowing students to develop strong foundational skills in both their mother tongue as well as in English. This gradual approach ensures that students are not overwhelmed by the dual task of learning content and language simultaneously. As students become more proficient, English can play a larger role in the medium of instruction, particularly at the secondary level.

A balanced approach, where English is introduced as a subject in the early years and gradually becomes a medium of instruction, ensures that students achieve both linguistic competence and academic success in a globalised world.

Respect for Cultural and Linguistic Rootedness: NEP 2020 considers rootedness in one's culture and language as a matter of immense pride. It points to the importance of acknowledging one's language and culture and creating a learning environment that celebrates the diversity present in the classroom.

Let us look at the following classroom example to understand these provisions in a better manner:

Grade 1 students in a school in Odisha come from varied linguistic backgrounds. Most of the children speak Odia, but a few tribal students speak Kui, their tribal language. The teacher feels that the children who speak Kui are reticent in the class and decides to follow the recommendations of NEP 2020. S/he redesigns his/her classroom teaching practices accordingly. Following the idea that children should be taught in their home language, the teacher begins each day with an activity where students greet each other in their home languages. S/he also introduces basic English through songs and rhymes to align with the three-language formula. While teaching concepts in environmental studies, s/he uses storybooks and bilingual flashcards in Odia and Kui. During the mathematics class, while teaching counting, the teacher introduces the numbers in both languages and finally in English, and invites children to repeat after her. This exposure to multiple languages helped in making children more confident and curious about new languages while staying grounded in their own. The teacher's vision helped transform the classroom scenario, thereby bringing the provisions of NEP 2020 to life.

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In a similar way, we can also integrate the recommendations of NEP 2020 in our classrooms. While the policy outlines the recommendations for the implementation of bi/multilingualism in our classrooms, it is the NCFs that tell us how to translate these recommendations into fruitful practices. Let us now look at the key provisions laid down in the NCF-FS 2022 and NCF-SE 2023.

1.3.2 Key Provisions from NCF-FS 2022 and NCF-SE 2023

Joyful and Meaningful Learning: Both the NCF-FS and the NCF-SE emphasise that early education should be accompanied by play and activity. This will give way to natural and joyful language acquisition among children because they will learn from their experiences.

Use of Familiar Language: Both the NCF-FS and the NCF-SE encourage the use of a familiar language as the medium of communication and instruction. This creates an inclusive environment where children feel safe, valued, and understood. Since children learn concepts most rapidly and deeply in the language that they are comfortable with, i.e. their home language, the primary medium of instruction, would optimally be the child's home language/mother tongue/familiar language in the Foundational Stage.

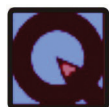
Use of Contextual Content: It is suggested that, as far as possible, content that is locally and culturally relevant, such as folk tales, songs, and rhymes, should be used in the classroom. This will make new concepts relatable and will bridge the gap between classroom learning and the lived experiences of the child.

Multilingual Environment: The documents emphasise using multilingualism as a resource in the classroom. They suggest creating an environment where all languages thrive and co-exist at the same time. Children should be encouraged to share their knowledge and experiences in the language they are most comfortable with and should be exposed to and immersed in multiple oral languages (also referred to as L2 and L3) from an early age. Furthermore, it is emphasised to ensure the presence of teachers and parents in schools, so that at least two or preferably three languages are present with children on a regular basis.

Teacher Support and Training: Proper training and support should be provided to teachers to help them understand the nuances of pedagogy and other inclusive strategies to strengthen the teaching learning process. Teachers are expected to help students in the development of reading and writing through the language R1, which is preferably the home language L1 whenever possible.



(Please note that by R1 we mean the language in which a child first learns the concept of reading and writing, R2 the second such language, and R3 the third such language, and so on.) It is opined that once the concept of reading and writing is developed in a child in R1, the use of additional scripts can be gradually introduced. The aim for students to become independent readers and writers in R1 by age 8 (Grade 3).



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 1.1

1. Fill in the blanks-
 - a. The policy reiterates and emphasises the _____ language formula as opined in the earlier policies and documents.
 - b. The NEP 2020 propagates the idea of teaching English as a _____ within a multilingual framework, especially at the primary level
2. Which of the following will bridge the gap between school and home?
 - a. Teaching in the home language
 - b. using rhymes, songs, and folk tales
 - c. using knowledge that is locally available
 - d. all of the above are relevant
3. According to NEP 2020, the medium of instruction until at least Grade 5 should preferably be:
 - a. English only
 - b. Hindi or Sanskrit
 - c. Home language/mother tongue/local language
 - d. Any foreign language
4. In your opinion, why is it important to teach children in their home language or mother tongue?
5. What is the three-language formula, and what are the ways in which it can be applied?
6. List two ways NCF-FS 2022 supports language learning in the early years of schooling.

Ans. 1. a. three, b. subject
2. d
3. c

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1.4 UNDERSTANDING BI/MULTI LINGUALISM

As we have seen that the policy gives importance to the home language of the children, thereby also emphasising their lived experiences. Therefore, it becomes important for us to understand the concept of bi/multilingualism and how it can be implemented in our classrooms.

Bilingualism means the ability of an individual to speak, read, and write in at least two languages, and Multilingualism is the ability to be dexterous in more than two languages. Many children grow up in a language-rich environment where they are exposed to two or three languages as part of their everyday life.

For instance, a child may speak Bhili with grandparents at home, use Hindi in the market or with friends and neighbors, and hear English in school or on television. As it is seen through this example, the child is getting exposed to multiple languages at a very early stage and is navigating through a multilingual world even before venturing into formal classroom teaching. This ability of the child is a very natural and dynamic process that takes place based on the social, cultural, and environmental needs. It is a noteworthy fact that children do not learn languages one at a time in isolation, but they pick up languages unconsciously by listening, speaking, playing and interacting with others around them. Let us now look at the key benefits of bi/multilingualism.

1.4.1 Importance of Multilingualism

There is ample research evidence that multilingualism supports the overall development of children. It should be used as a resource in the classroom rather than acting as a barrier to learning. Multilingualism helps children develop higher-order thinking skills and to connect faster and deeply with the world around them. Let us look at the importance of multilingualism in our classrooms:

Boosts Cognitive Development: Knowledge of more than one language boosts memory, develops problem-solving skills, and flexible thinking. Switching between languages also helps children learn the skill of multitasking and adapt to different situations quickly.

Cultural Connection and mutual respect: Multilingual children display the ability to understand and appreciate the differences among cultures. They are sensitive towards cultural differences and have a sense of respect towards people coming from different backgrounds and cultures. Thus, when the school encourages the use of home languages, children feel more comfortable, valued, and strongly connected to their identity and community.

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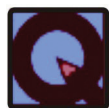
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Easier Learning: It is an established fact that children learn better when they associate new concepts with words and ideas that they already know in their home language. Moving between languages helps them to understand new topics in a better manner.

Social and Emotional Growth: Expression in more than one language improves communication and builds confidence. Children grow socially and emotionally when they are able to connect with their friends and other people around them. This encourages empathy and respect for other languages and cultures.

Let us look at the following example to understand the key benefits of multilingualism in a better way:

Meena is a young girl from Jharkhand. She speaks Kurukh, a tribal language, at home with her family, Hindi with her neighbours and is now learning to speak English in her school with her teachers and friends. The teacher recognises this unique combination and instead of forcing her to speak in English or Hindi, she involves Meena and asks her to share a story or song that her mother told her in Kurukh. With basic knowledge of Kurukh, the teacher tries to retell the same story in Hindi by adding basic English words to it. As a result, Meena feels that her home language is being valued, and she becomes more open and ready to learn Hindi and English. This approach not only helps to create a joyful and inclusive environment, but also lets Meena take pride in her home language while learning new ones.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 1.2

1. Fill in the blanks.
 - a. _____ is the ability to be able to speak more than two languages.
 - b. Multilingualism boosts _____ development among children.
2. A person who speaks more than two languages is called a
 - a. Polyglot
 - b. Polychrome
 - c. Polygon
 - d. Polylingual
3. List two cognitive benefits of multilingualism.

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4. How can using a child's home language support classroom learning?
5. Why, in your opinion, is multilingualism considered a strength in Indian classrooms?

Ans. 1. a. Multilingualism, b. cognitive 2. a

1.5 MULTILINGUALISM AS A CLASSROOM RESOURCE

Now, that we have understood the importance of bi/multilingualism, we also need to know how to implement it in our classrooms.

We all will agree to the fact that, given the diverse languages in a country like India, children enter school with their prior linguistic experiences and backgrounds. Their native language or mother tongue shapes their identity, helps them in culture acquisition, and activates their thought process. When teachers recognise this diversity and utilise the varied experiences of our students, we turn a possible challenge into a powerful teaching resource.

This has to be understood that multilingualism is not about knowing many languages, but it is the process of putting them into use in a meaningful and creative manner. A successful multilingual teacher is one who makes every child seen, heard, and valued. Let us now understand the key benefits of multilingualism and how it can be employed as a resource in our classrooms.

1.5.1 Key Benefits of Using Multilingualism as a Resource

Practicing multilingualism in the classroom has various benefits. Some of them are listed below:

- Children learn and understand better when new concepts are introduced and linked to what they already know.
- Children feel safe and respected in their home language.
- Using a child's home language shows respect for their background.
- Children feel included when they are taught in their home language and are more likely to participate actively.
- Children build confidence, while hesitation and fear are minimised.
- It helps children become better at learning new languages, including English.



1.5.2 Strategies to Use Multilingualism in the Classroom

The benefits of Multilingualism underscore the importance of using children's home language in the process of teaching and learning. Let us discuss some simple, practical strategies that teachers can employ to create a language-rich environment.

Increase talk time in the classroom: Teachers can allow children to share an idea, a story, or even answers in their home language. Increasing talk time helps children to adjust to their surroundings and get involved in the process. The teacher can then gently introduce new terms in the school language. The basic idea is to remove inhibitions and create a stress-free environment for expression.

Using local stories and songs: Teachers can begin their classes with a local folk tale or a rhyme in the home language of the children. Then the theme of the lesson can be connected in Hindi or in English. The aim is to create a contextualised learning environment where children can relate to their learning.

Translanguaging: Translanguaging emerges as a powerful tool that supports learning in multilingual classrooms. It encourages the flexible use of languages, rather than keeping languages separate in watertight compartments. For instance, a child may read a story from a book in Hindi, discuss it in their home language, Bhojpuri, and then do a written assignment in English. This helps children connect new knowledge with their previous knowledge and build upon their lived experiences. Translanguaging offers a practical solution to teachers as well by helping them to integrate the diverse linguistic backgrounds in the teaching learning process. Translanguaging promotes cognitive development, bridges gaps between languages, and makes the process of learning more inclusive and joyful.

Bilingual Instruction and Code-switching: This is an effective strategy to support multilingualism in primary classrooms. In linguistically diverse contexts like our country, children come to school with at least one or two languages with them. Therefore, bilingual instruction involves using two languages, typically the home language of the child and the language of the school. This approach helps to bridge the understanding of students and create a stress-free and supportive learning environment. For instance, the teacher introduces a new concept in EVS in Hindi or English and further discusses it in the child's mother tongue.

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Code-switching, on the other hand, is the intentional alternation between two or more languages existing in the classroom. Code-switching is generally done within the same sentence or conversation. The teacher may intentionally switch between the child's home language and the language of the school to clarify meanings, connect new knowledge to previous knowledge, and for the purpose of classroom instructions. Code-switching as a strategy supports flexibility, develops respect for linguistic diversity, and creates an inclusive environment.

Multilingual learning teaching material: The teacher can create classroom charts, signs, and word walls in multiple languages. For example, the word 'water' can be labelled in Hindi, English, Santhali, and Kurukh. Multilingual books or wall stories wherein simple texts that include two or three languages side by side can be utilised to help children associate and form connections. The NCERT, in collaboration with the CIIL (Central Institute of Indian Languages) has developed a set of 52 Primers in Indian Languages. These Primers in Indian languages were released on 9th March 2024 and are supposed to become an inspiration to promote multilingual education in India. These primers are available on the official website of NCERT.

Total Physical Response (TPR): TPR is an effective strategy that involves the use of physical movement to align with verbal input. For example, when the teacher says 'sit' or 'jump' in the class, both in the home language and the school language, the children respond by performing the activity. This method works effectively in multilingual classrooms as it helps children to participate and form connections between the words and the actions associated with them. It is particularly helpful for those students who are still in the process of developing confidence in the school language because it allows them to fully use their bodies as a natural response to the cue.

Thus, from the above discussion, it is clear that by incorporating and practicing these strategies, we as teachers can create more inclusive spaces in our classrooms where children feel accepted and are able to build strong foundations in language. These strategies support the goals of NEP 2020, which encourages child-centric language policies in early education.

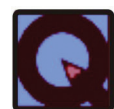
Let us look at a case study from a primary school in Maharashtra to help us understand how these strategies can be implemented in our classrooms:

In a primary school in Maharashtra, the teacher realised that the children in her class came from tribal communities. They speak Konkani at home, while the activities conducted in class are mostly done in Marathi. As a result, the

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CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 1.3

1. Fill in the blanks
 - a. _____ is an effective strategy which involves the use of physical movement to align with verbal input.
 - b. Translanguaging promotes cognitive development and bridges gaps between _____.
2. Which of the following is not a strategy to implement Multilingualism in the classroom?
 - a. Decrease talk time in the classroom
 - b. Multilingual learning teaching material
 - c. Using local stories and songs
 - d. Bilingual Instruction and Code-switching
3. Which of the following is not a benefit of multilingualism in early childhood education?
 - a. Enhances cognitive flexibility
 - b. Strengthens emotional development
 - c. Reduces learning motivation
 - d. Builds identity and confidence
4. How does using children's home languages help build confidence?
5. What is peer support, and how does it help in a multilingual classroom?

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6. Why should we display multilingual labels in the classroom?

- Ans.** 1. a. Total Physical Response, b. languages
2. a
3. c

1.6 CHALLENGES IN PROMOTING MULTILINGUALISM AND SOLUTIONS

While the idea of using multilingualism in the classroom appears to be fascinating, powerful, and inclusive, it becomes a daunting task for teachers to implement it practically. The challenges faced by teachers are mostly extrinsic in nature, for example, challenges posed by the school system, challenges of limited resources available, and personal challenges owing to the limited experience and confidence among teachers regarding multiple languages. However, with proper planning, support and collaboration, these challenges can be minimised and transformed into potential opportunities. Let us look at a few common challenges that are faced by teachers and the possible practical solutions to them.

1.6.1 Common Challenges Faced by Teachers

Lack of Teaching Materials in Local Languages: Owing to the vast number of languages and dialects spoken in the country, it becomes practically difficult to prepare learning-teaching material in all local languages. Hence, if the teacher is unaware of the local languages, they may face challenges when it comes to explaining concepts in the local language. Moreover, English is often viewed as a ‘prestige’ language, while local languages may be undervalued, leading to a diminished role for ‘students’ mother tongues in education.

Emphasis on using only the Official Medium of Instruction: Many schools are very rigid regarding the medium of instruction. Teachers may feel compelled to teach only in Hindi, English, or the state’s official language as per the directions received from higher authorities. This may be due to school policies and, many times, also due to parental expectations where English proficiency is often equated with academic success and economic advancement.

Teachers may not know all the Languages Spoken by Students: It is possible in a country like India that the teacher may be completely unaware of the language of the school or the state in which they are posted, particularly in a government setup. Moreover, it is not realistic to expect the teacher to know all the languages in a class where students speak multiple languages. Thus, many times, due to this gaps may be created in communication.



Insufficient Teacher Training and Support: Teachers may essentially lack the skills, strategies, and support that are required to manage multilingual classrooms. Insufficient teacher training programs can be one factor responsible for this. Inadequate training in multilingual pedagogies results in challenges in balancing the use of English with local languages.

1.6.2 Practical Solutions for Teachers

Challenges give way to opportunities; therefore, despite these challenges, there are a few simple, creative, and community-based strategies that can be practiced by teachers for transforming these challenges into potential opportunities. Let us look at a few possible solutions for the challenges faced by teachers in implementing multilingualism in spirit.

Table 1.1: Overcoming Challenges in Multilingual Classrooms

Challenges	Solutions
Lack of Teaching Materials in Local Languages	• Collect folk tales, rhymes, and songs from the community. • Invite parents or elders to share stories in local languages. • Create simple picture books or posters with children.
Emphasis on Using Only the Official Medium of Instruction	• Use home languages as a bridge to help children understand concepts before shifting to the official language. • Use translanguaging to allow switching between languages for better understanding.
Teachers may not know all the Languages spoken by Students	• Use gestures, pictures, and visuals to support communication. • Pair children with a classmate who speaks the same language for peer support. • Learn a few key words in children's languages to build trust and connection.
Insufficient Teacher Training and Support	• Participate in workshops, online courses, or communities of practice. • Collaborate with other teachers to co-plan multilingual activities. • Reflect regularly on what works and adapt strategies.

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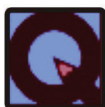


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To understand this better, let us look at the following example of a school where a teacher tried to overcome a language barrier in class by applying targeted strategies for the same.

In a government school in Odisha, a teacher realised that four of her students spoke in Kui, which was their home language, while the rest of the class spoke in Odia. As a result, the four students slowly became reticent and took very little interest in classroom activities. The teacher herself did not speak Kui, but she designed a simple solution to this problem.

The next day, she paired the four Kui-speaking students with Odia-speaking classmates who could help translate words and concepts. She tried to use drawings, songs, and local objects to explain the lessons. During story time, she also invited a grandmother from the local community to narrate a folktale in Kui, which she later repeated in Odia. This small effort made by the teacher made the Kui-speaking children comfortable, feel welcomed, and curious to learn and participate.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 1.4

1. Which of the following is not a challenge faced by teachers
 - a. Teachers may not know all the Languages spoken by Students
 - b. Emphasis on Using Only the Official Medium of Instruction
 - c. Insufficient Teacher Training and Support
 - d. Too many languages in the classroom
2. A classroom strategy that supports multilingualism is:
 - a. Punishing children for using their home language
 - b. Encouraging peer translation and storytelling in multiple languages
 - c. Limiting communication to English only
 - d. Ignoring linguistic differences
3. List two ways to create or collect learning materials in local languages.
4. Why is collaboration among teachers and students important for promoting multilingualism?
5. State any two common challenges that are not mentioned above faced by you in multilingual classrooms.
6. Suggest one practical solution to these challenges that you face in the classroom.

Ans. 1. D, 2. B

1.7 ACTIVITIES TO PROMOTE MULTILINGUALISM

We have realised this fact that multilingualism is not about using different languages in the classroom; rather, it is a much broader concept. It is about celebrating and respecting the language of every child and helping them feel valued, heard, and understood. Through careful planning and practice, teachers can create an environment of trust and mutual respect among children. These activities will not only augment vocabulary and communication skills but will also help in fostering joyful and meaningful learning experiences.

Let us look at a few activities that can help teachers in the classroom:

Multilingual Story Circle: Children grow up hearing stories from the elders at home. Stories form an integral part of our childhood and, therefore, are a powerful way to connect with children. It helps them to express their ideas, emotions, and feelings in the language they are most comfortable with. Multilingual storytelling will help involve all students in the class.

Directions: The teacher can invite children to narrate stories in the language they speak at home. Picture cues can also be taken, and children can be asked to weave stories around them. For example, the children can tell stories in Gondi, Bundeli, or Santali. Children can be encouraged to use drawings, puppets, and other locally available props. After the story, the teacher or other children in class can retell it in Hindi or English. This can be followed by a discussion of the message and the story. For instance, a child narrates a local folk tale in her/his language. The teacher writes the keywords on the blackboard and, if possible equivalents in Hindi or English, and then asks the children to act it out in their own language in groups.



Fig. 1.2: Example of Picture Cues (Mridang I, NCERT, 2025, p. 37)

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Language Corners: Dealing with multiple languages is a challenge for the teacher. Language corners come in handy in such a situation. The teacher can create dedicated language corners for different languages in the class, thereby creating working spaces for languages to flourish simultaneously.

Directions: For the purpose of creating language corners in the classroom, the teacher can arrange books in different languages, like picture books, comics, or translated stories. They can create charts showing numbers, colours, or animals in different local languages. A blackboard space can be dedicated to the word of the week in two or three languages spoken by the children. For example, the teacher can create a poster showing the word ‘water’ in different languages: ‘Pani’ in Hindi, ‘Jalam’ in Sanskrit, ‘Neeru’ in Kannada, and ‘Aab’ in Urdu, with drawings and pictures.

Rhymes and Songs in Different Languages: Songs and rhymes are always a fun way to involve children in the process of learning. These are not only easy to remember but also help in developing vocabulary and language fluency.

Directions: The teacher can ask children to sing rhymes or songs they know in their home language. Wherever possible, the teacher can make use of gestures, actions, and visuals to support the spoken word. The teacher can also translate some well-known English rhymes to Hindi or the home language of the children for better comprehension. Common rhymes like the one in the picture can be taken up in the class. Such simple rhymes can be translated into local languages that are available in the class.

Parts of the Body

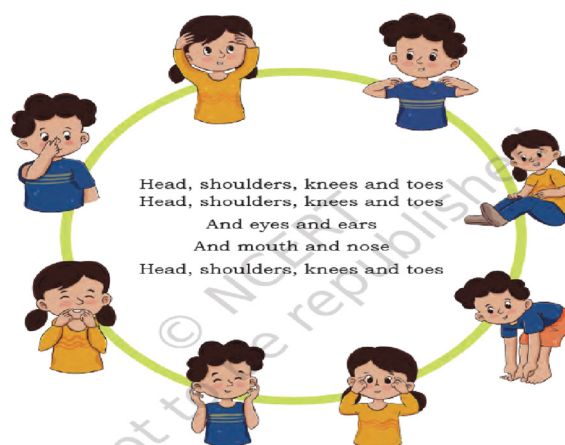


Fig. 1.3: Example of Songs (Mridang I, NCERT, 2025, p. 3)



Role Play and Dramatisation: The NEP and the NCFs emphasise experiential learning and learning by doing. Pretend play is an important milestone of early childhood years, and role play and dramatisation make learning contextual, relevant, and interactive.

Directions: The teacher can conduct role play based on contextual and local events in the classroom. Pictures can be chosen from the textbooks and based on the pictures, role-play activities can be organised. For example, situations like shopping at the market, a visit to the doctor, and travelling by bus or train can be enacted by students in the class. The children should be allowed to use the language that they are most comfortable with. The teacher can also encourage bilingual or multilingual dialogues. For example, two children act as a shopkeeper and a customer. One speaks in their home language and the other replies in Hindi. Then they switch roles and repeat in English.



Fig. 1.4: Example of Role Play Cues (Mridang I, NCERT, 2025, p. 89)

Word Walls and Picture Dictionaries: A Word Wall in the class helps children acquire new words and retain them in their active vocabulary. An interactive display of new vocabulary in multiple languages reinforces their acquisition.

Directions: The teacher can choose five to ten words on a weekly basis, these words can range from fruit names, body parts, or words from the local context. These words can be displayed creatively in different languages spoken in the class. Children can be involved and asked to prepare simple, handmade pictures

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and drawings for illustration. For example, 'Apple' can be written in different vocabulary equivalents like 'Seb' in Hindi, 'Safarjan' in Gujarati, 'Apel' in Bengali, etc



Fig. 1.5: Vocabulary Word Wall (ELL Strategies & Misconceptions, n.d.)

Bridge the Words: The objective of this game is to help children build vocabulary by connecting them with words from other languages.

Directions: The teacher writes common English words on the board, like tree, water, book, sun, friend, etc. The teacher can then show pictures associated with these words and asks the students to name the equivalent of those words in their home language. A word bridge chart with different columns can be created on the board with the words written on them. This activity can be extended to form simple basic sentences in different languages. A simple example has been given below to illustrate this activity in four languages: Hindi, English, Gujarati and Marathi

Sun - सूर्य (Surya) / सूर्य (Surya) / सूरज (Sooraj)

Tree - वृक्ष (Vruksh) / झाड़ (Zhad) / पेड़ (Ped)

Simple sentences:

“The sun is bright.” -

Gujarati- સૂર્ય તેજસ્વી છે

Marathi- सूर्य तेजस्वी आहे

Hindi- सूरज चमकीला है



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Spot the Difference: Children enjoy activities based on pictures. A simple activity like Spot the Difference can help them to develop the skill of observation and vocabulary through multilingual expression.

Directions: The teacher can begin by showing a picture to the students. First, she can ask the students to explain what is happening in the picture in their own languages. Next, she can introduce a second picture similar to the first one but with minimal differences between them. The activity can then be extended by asking the students to spot the differences in different languages. A simple example can be found below:



Fig. 1.6: Example of Spot the Differences (*Mridang II*, NCERT, 2025, p. 51)

Gujarati: "અહીં ગાદલા છે, પણ ત્યાં નથી."

Marathi: "इथे उशा आहेत, पण तिथे नाहीत."

Hindi: "यहाँ तकिये हैं, पर वहाँ नहीं।"

Now describe in English: "There are pillows here, but not there."

Table 1.2: Multilingual Classroom Activities

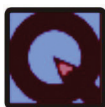
Activity Type	Languages Involved	Learning Outcome
Storytelling	Home language, Hindi/English	Expression, Listening, Cultural Sharing
Language Corner	Home, school, regional languages	Vocabulary, Reading
Songs and Rhymes	Any language spoken by children	Pronunciation, Rhythm, Comprehension
Role Play	Mixed language (flexible)	Communication, Social Skills

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Word Wall	Home, school and regional languages	Visual memory, Spelling, Multisensory learning
Bridge the Words	Any language spoken by children	Vocabulary, Translation, Sentence Formation
Spot the Difference	Any language spoken by children	Speaking, Observation, Translation



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 1.5

- Fill in the blanks.
 - A _____ in the class helps children to acquire new words and retain them in their active vocabulary.
 - The NEP and the NCFs emphasise _____ learning.
- Songs and Rhymes help to build
 - Pronunciation
 - Rhythm
 - Comprehension
 - All of the above
- Describe one multilingual classroom activity you would try and why.
- How can a word wall support multilingual learning?
- What is the importance of role-play in supporting language use?
- List two activities that you use in your classrooms.

Ans. 1. a. word wall, b. experiential, 2. d



1.8 LET US SUM UP

- The National Education Policy 2020 and the National Curriculum Frameworks recommend the use of home language or the mother tongue as the medium of instruction up to at least Grade 5, and preferably until Grade 8 and beyond.
- It recommends a smooth transition from the home language to the school language.

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- It also gives emphasis to bi/multilingualism, which is very commonly found in homes.
- These language abilities of children should be seen as opportunities and not barriers.
- When utilised effectively, multilingualism helps in promoting higher-order thinking skills and building strong cultural identities.
- Multilingualism is not a challenge to overcome but a treasure to embrace. The rich linguistic diversity of Bharat can be utilised as a powerful resource in the classroom.
- When teachers effectively make use of the multiple languages that children speak in the class, they give way to classrooms that are inclusive, engaging, and effective for all.



1.9 END EXERCISES

1. Fill in the blanks.

- NEP 2020 recommends that the medium of instruction until at least Grade _____ should be the child's home language, mother tongue, or local language.
- Multilingualism helps in strengthening children's _____ and _____ growth.
- One of the major classroom strategies to promote multilingualism is the use of _____ and _____ in different languages.
- Teachers can use _____ cards to bridge vocabulary across languages in early grade classrooms.
- A significant challenge in multilingual classrooms is lack of _____ in multiple languages for teaching-learning materials.

2. Match the Following:

Concept	Description
i. Home language	a. Includes mother tongue and local dialects
ii. Picture-word cards	b. Using multiple languages flexibly within the classroom
iii. Translanguaging	c. Encourages empathy, identity formation, and belonging

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iv. Multilingual songs	d. Promotes the use of the home language as a medium of instruction
v. NEP 2020 language policy	e. Teaching tool for vocabulary building in many languages

3. What is a common challenge in implementing multilingual education?
 - a. Children resisting the use of their mother tongue
 - b. Teachers being trained in multilingual pedagogy
 - c. Lack of accessible teaching-learning materials in all home languages
 - d. Abundance of local language storybooks
4. What are the key recommendations of NEP 2020 regarding the use of language at the foundational stage?
5. Explain how multilingualism can support children's cognitive and emotional development.
6. List three classroom strategies with examples that promote the use of bi-/multilingualism.
7. What are the challenges teachers face while promoting multilingualism, and how can they be addressed and resolved?
8. Design a multilingual classroom activity that you can implement in a Grade 2 class.
9. Reflect on your own classroom and state how inclusive it is of children's languages and cultures.

3.9. REFERENCES

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